



COMBAT Unready

Proposals for basic infantry equipment worth Rs 34,000 crore pile up as red tape jams the country's war preparedness

By Sandeep Unnithan

A t a recent closed door meeting to review the army's infantry, a general took the podium to explain the virtues of the standard issue hand grenade. In production in India since World War II, the pineapple shaped grenade is designed to explode and scatter 36 pieces of shrapnel. "But you'll be lucky if it breaks into two. You are better off throwing it at the head of the terrorist," the general said amidst polite laughter. His black humour was not without reason. Soldiers have flung the pineapple-sized explosive, the 36-M, at terrorists to see them walk away unscathed and the army has been known to use the China- and Pakistan-made hand grenades it recovers from terrorists.

Yet, unreliable grenades are not the only problem. During the 1999 Kargil War, a shortage of high altitude clothing and infantry weapons prompted the then army chief General V. P. Malik to famously say that the Indian Army would "fight with what it had". A decade later, things don't seem to have changed much. The nearly four lakh foot soldiers that make up the world's second largest army continue to fight with what they have. The deficiencies are in the bread-and-butter equipment—assault rifles, machine guns and rocket launcher rounds which the infantry uses almost every day in counter-insurgency operations in Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) and the North-east. The 9 mm carbine and the 7.62 mm light machine gun are being phased out. Unhappy with the indigenous 5.56 mm INSAS rifle introduced as the standard infantry weapon a decade ago, the army now wants to import a new assault rifle but replacements are still years away.

In a presentation made to army headquarters last year, the army's infantry directorate projected a Rs 34,000 crore backlog of orders for its prime fighting arm, the infantry. This includes basic equipment like

A ROCKET LAUNCHER TEAM MOVES INTO A FIREFIGHT IN KASHMIR. THE ARMY HAS BEEN UNABLE TO REPLACE THEIR OUTDATED EQUIPMENT—HELMETS, BOOTS, BULLET-PROOF JACKETS AND ASSAULT RIFLES.

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